WOMAN NEXT DOOR · FREE MEMBER RESOURCE

Sell Yourself

The Woman Next Door guide to landing the job, the client and the yes.

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For her. With her. Beside her.

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01 · WHY THIS MATTERS

Ladies, start here

Every application, interview, networking chat and client conversation is a small sale. The product is you. This guide shows you how to sell it well, honestly and without feeling pushy.

You don't need a sales job or a marketing degree to use these skills. You already persuade people every day: you convince a customer to stay, talk a friend into a plan, or get a supplier to give you a better price. The difference now is doing it on purpose, for your own career.

The numbers say women are holding back

LinkedIn studied billions of interactions between job seekers and companies on its platform. Compared with men, women:

16%	26%	16%
less likely to apply after viewing a job	less likely to ask for a referral	**more** likely to get hired when they do apply

Source: LinkedIn, *Gender Insights Report* (2019).

> **Read that last number again.** When women put themselves forward, they're more likely to win. The problem usually isn't ability. It's asking. The rest of this guide is about asking well.

Why “selling yourself” isn't bragging

Good selling is not exaggerating or pressuring. It's understanding what someone needs, then showing clearly how you can help. That is exactly what an employer or client wants to hear. Staying quiet about what you can do doesn't make you humble. It just makes the decision harder for the person who might hire you.

Say it so they hear it

Many of us describe big skills in small words. "I just do customer service." "I help out with the church events." Hiring managers can't see the skill if you shrink it.

What employers say they look for

In the National Association of Colleges and Employers' *Job Outlook 2025* survey, nearly 9 in 10 employers said they look for evidence of problem-solving on a résumé, and about 8 in 10 look for teamwork. Written communication, initiative, work ethic and technical skills each mattered to at least 7 in 10. In LinkedIn's 2019 survey of over 5,000 hiring professionals, 92% agreed strong soft skills are becoming more important, and 89% said bad hires usually have weak soft skills.

So the skills you use every day are the ones in demand. You just need the right words for them.

Try the translation

How we often say it	How to say it on a résumé or in an interview
"I deal with customer complaints."	Resolve customer issues and keep clients coming back. *(problem-solving)*
"I sell things on the side."	Run a small business end to end: sales, marketing, pricing and customer care. *(initiative)*
"I help plan events at church."	Coordinate events, vendors and volunteer teams on a budget. *(teamwork, organisation)*
"Everyone comes to me with questions."	Train new team members and serve as the go-to problem-solver. *(leadership)*
"I post for my business online."	Create social media content and grow an online audience. *(marketing, written communication)*
"I keep track of the stock."	Manage inventory and orders to avoid shortages and waste. *(attention to detail)*

Add a number wherever you can. "Handled about 40 calls a day." "Grew my page from 200 to 1,500 followers." "Planned a 120-person event." Numbers turn a claim into proof. Only use numbers that are true; a good estimate you can explain is fine.

Your turn. Write three things you do often, then rename each one.

1. I _____ → _____
2. I _____ → _____
3. I _____ → _____

03 · YOUR 30-SECOND PITCH

Know your answer to “So, what do you do?”

You'll be asked some version of this at interviews, meetups, events, even in line at the bank. A short, ready answer makes you memorable instead of flustered.

The three-part formula

1. Who you are	Your name and the work you do, in plain words.
2. Your proof	What you're good at, backed by one result or example.
3. What you want	The role, client or connection you're looking for, and how you'd help.

Example

> “I'm Kerry-Ann, and I work in customer care for an online retailer. I'm the person my team calls when a client is upset. Last year I helped bring our complaint resolution time down by a full day. I'm looking to move into an account management role where I can keep clients happy and help them buy more.”
>
> *About 25 seconds out loud. Who she is, her proof, and what she wants, with no rambling.*

Fill in yours

Hi, I'm _____, and I _____.

I'm really good at _____,

for example, _____.

Right now I'm looking for _____.

Make it sound like you

- **Say it out loud and time it.** If it runs past 40 seconds, cut it down.
- **Have two versions:** one for job settings, one for business and networking.
- **End with an open door,** like “What about you?” or “Do you know anyone hiring for that?”
- **Skip the apology.** Drop “I'm only…” and “I just…” from your pitch.

04 • INTERVIEW LIKE A SELLER

Think like the person hiring

A good salesperson doesn't start by listing features. She finds out what the customer needs, then shows how she solves it. An interview works the same way.

Before: find their problem

- Read the job post twice. Circle the skills and tasks they repeat; those are their priorities.
- Look at the company's website and social pages. What are they proud of? What are they trying to grow?
- Ask yourself: *what problem will this hire solve for them?* Build your answers around that.

During: answer with proof, using STAR

When you hear "Tell me about a time when…", the interviewer wants a real story. The STAR method, a framework used widely by career services, keeps your story short and clear:

Situation	Set the scene in a sentence or two.
Task	What you needed to get done.
Action	What **you** did. Spend most of your answer here and say "I", not "we".
Result	What happened because of you. Add a number if you can.

Question: "Tell me about a time you handled a difficult customer."

S — A regular customer called upset because her order arrived damaged right before a birthday party. **T** — I needed to fix it that same day and keep her business. **A** — I apologised, arranged a replacement from our other branch, and called her back myself to confirm the pickup time. **R** — She got her order in time, left us a five-star review, and still orders from us monthly.

Prepare stories for these

- "Tell me about yourself." (Use your 30-second pitch, then add a little more.)
- "Why should we hire you?" (Connect your proof to their problem.)
- "Tell me about a time you solved a problem / worked on a team / made a mistake."
- "What's your greatest strength?" (Pick one and give an example.)

Close the conversation

Never leave without knowing the next step. Before you go, ask one or two of these:

- "What would success look like in this role after the first three months?"
- "What's the biggest challenge the person in this role will face?"
- "What are the next steps, and when can I expect to hear back?"

05 · FOLLOW UP AND STAND OUT

The sale happens in the follow-up

Most people stop selling the moment they walk out of the room. A short, thoughtful message keeps you in the conversation after everyone else has gone quiet.

68%	16%
of recruiters and hiring managers said a thank-you note affects their decision	said they had dismissed a candidate for not sending one

Source: TopResume survey of 358 recruiters and hiring managers (2017).

Send it within 24 hours, to every person who interviewed you. Keep it short, mention something specific you talked about, and proofread before you hit send.

After an interview (email)

Subject: Thank you, [Role] interview

Hi [Name],

Thank you for meeting with me today about the [Role] position. I enjoyed learning about [something specific they mentioned], and it made me even more excited about the role.

From our conversation, it sounds like you need someone who can [their main need]. I'm confident my experience [your matching proof] would help your team do that.

Please let me know if I can share anything else. I look forward to hearing from you.

Kind regards,
[Your name]
[Phone number]

After meeting someone at an event (WhatsApp or LinkedIn)

Hi [Name], it was lovely meeting you at [event] on [day]! I really enjoyed our chat about [topic]. I'd love to stay in touch. [Optional: Would you be open to a quick 15-minute call sometime next week?]

After a sales chat with a possible client

Hi [Name], thanks again for your time today. As promised, here's [the price list / link / info] we talked about. Based on what you shared about [their goal], I think [your offer] would be a great fit. Would [day] work for a quick follow-up to answer any questions?

06 · YOUR RÉSUMÉ'S FIRST IMPRESSION

Make it easy to say yes

Your résumé is your sales page. Its first job is to get a busy reader to keep reading.

> **How quick is the first look?** In a 2018 eye-tracking study by the job site Ladders, recruiters spent an average of about 7.4 seconds on their first scan of a résumé, and looked at job titles more than anything else. Critics point out the study didn't share full details of its method, so treat the exact number loosely. The lesson still holds: that first glance is fast, so make it count.

Quick wins

- **Clear headings and a simple layout.** Fancy borders, graphics and tiny fonts make it harder to scan.
- **Job titles that stand out.** Bold them so the eye lands on them first.
- **Bullets that show results,** not just duties. Use your translated skills from Part 02.
- **A short summary at the top:** two or three lines that echo your 30-second pitch.
- **Tailor it to each job.** Use the same words the job post uses for the skills you really have.
- **One page is usually enough** unless you have many years of relevant experience.

> **Find these in the Resources tab:** the *Harvard Resume & Cover Letter Guide* for sample résumés and action words, *Canva Resume Templates* for clean designs, and the *Job Sites Guide* for where to send it. To build real sales skills, try *HubSpot Academy*.

Apply even if you don't tick every box

A widely cited finding, repeated in LinkedIn's research, is that women tend to apply only when they meet all of a job's requirements, while men often apply when they meet about 60%. Job posts are often a wish list. If you can do most of what's listed and you're willing to learn the rest, apply and let them decide.

07 · YOUR SELL YOURSELF CHECKLIST

Put it into practice

Tick these off over the next few weeks. Share your wins with the ladies in the group. We celebrate every one.

- [ ] I renamed at least three of my everyday skills in stronger words (Part 02).
- [ ] I added at least one true number or result to my résumé.
- [ ] I wrote my 30-second pitch and practised it out loud until it felt natural (Part 03).
- [ ] I have a job version and a business/networking version of my pitch.
- [ ] I prepared three STAR stories: solving a problem, working on a team, and handling a difficult person (Part 04).
- [ ] I wrote down two questions to ask at my next interview.
- [ ] I saved the thank-you and follow-up templates where I can find them quickly (Part 05).
- [ ] I applied for one role I felt “not quite ready” for.
- [ ] I asked someone I know for a referral, an introduction or advice.
- [ ] I started one free course from the Resources tab to grow my sales and marketing skills.

You don't have to do this alone. Practise your pitch with another member, ask for feedback on your résumé, or share an opening you've seen. That's what Woman Next Door is for.

For her. With her. Beside her.

SOURCES

Where our numbers come from

Every statistic in this guide was checked against its original publisher or a reputable report of it. All writing, examples and templates are original to Woman Next Door.

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A note from Woman Next Door

Everything in this guide comes from research Woman Next Door has gathered from the sources above. We work hard to keep it accurate, but information changes and mistakes can happen. If you spot anything incorrect or outdated, please let us know through the app so we can update it. Always do your own research before making important decisions.

This guide is general information to help you present yourself well. It isn't a guarantee of a job or professional career counselling. Hiring practices vary by country, industry and employer.